Fast Train On Slow Track

Designed for 180 kmph, India's flagship train hits barely half that. Its coaches may be modern and gleaming, but they are running on same old railway tracks, signals and systems

By AVISHEK G. DASTIDAR



ENGINEERING, INTERRUPTED
A Vande Bharat Express train

Imagine buying a Tesla built to race at 200 kmph, only to find yourself crawling at 20 through potholes, boxed in by auto-rickshaws. The thrill of owning sophisticated engineering disappears as you inch forward in traffic. That's exactly what it feels like to ride India's flagship train, the Vande Bharat Express. Designed to cruise at 180 kmph and officially permitted to run at 160 kmph due to track and safety limits, these gleaming orange rakes—built to be India's fastest—average just 76 kmph across the network, barely faster than the Rajdhani Express trains introduced in 1969. The paradox is striking: world-class technology, but outdated systems.

The Vande Bharat dazzles both inside and out—streamlined nose, airplane-style seats, Wi-Fi and sleek interiors. Passengers click selfies, thrilled to board what many see as India's answer to Europe's high-speed icons; over 25 million have already chosen Vande Bharat since it was flagged off in February 2019. "It feels like flying on the ground—so clean, so modern," beams Maansi, 28, who travelled from Delhi to Katra recently. Each 16-coach set now costs between Rs 115 crore and Rs 134 crore, several times a regular train's price. India runs 78 pairs of Vande Bharat trains today, but aims for 4,500 by 2047, investing billions to reshape rail travel. Trial runs have even touched 183 kmph, a testament to 'Make in India' engineering. The hype is real: with Vande Bharat, India seemed poised to enter the era of semi-high-speed rail.

But the illusion fades once the journey begins. In 2020-21, the trains ran at an average speed of 84.5 kmph. By 2023-24, that had fallen to 76.25 kmph. Speeds also vary across routes. The New Delhi-Varanasi service averages 95 kmph, but the Coimbatore-Bangalore Vande Bharat lumbers along at only 58 kmph—slower than many regular expresses (see *Slow Coaches*). Even on its fastest stretches, such as parts of the Delhi-Agra line, the train sprints to 160 kmph for a few moments before braking back down. "I paid extra for speed, but the Vande Bharat only saved me about 25 minutes compared to the Shatabdi's time. I could have taken that," bemoans Som Basu, 42, a regular passenger from Bengaluru to Chennai. With a Vande Bharat ticket costing Rs 1,100 vs Rs 900 for Shatabdi, passengers like him wonder whether the premium you pay just for comfort is worth it if it is not accompanied by significant time savings.